The Sales Side

What selling actually means when the product does not exist yet and cannot be tested. How sales differs from relationship management, how both differ from every other kind of sales in finance, and what they are really looking for.

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PART I

The map

1 How a client coverage function is organised

Most institutional asset managers split client coverage into some version of these. **The exact split varies by firm and by segment, and Goldman does not publish an org chart** — so hold this as the general shape rather than as CSG's structure. It is also a perfectly good question to ask them.

Function	What it owns
Sales / business development	New money. Prospects, searches, RFPs, pitches, winning mandates.
Relationship management / client advisory	Existing money. Retention, reviews, servicing, additional mandates from the same client.
Consultant relations	The gatekeepers — Mercer, Aon, WTW, LCP, Hymans. A specialist function because consultants control shortlists.
Product / investment specialists	Deep expertise in one strategy. They support both sales and RM, and they are the bridge to the portfolio managers.
Client service / operations	Reporting, onboarding, the machinery. Where your market openings work sat.

A caution. Plenty of firms run a *coverage* model instead, where one person owns a client end to end — winning and keeping. Even where sales and RM are separate, they work the same accounts constantly. **Do not describe them as two separate worlds**; describe them as two jobs that overlap heavily.

2 Sales versus relationship management: the real difference

The obvious answer is that sales wins and RM keeps. True, and shallow. The deeper difference is *what you are asking the client to do.*

> Sales asks for a **decision**. Relationship management asks for **continued inaction**.

That single distinction generates almost everything else:

	SALES	RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT
You are asking for	A commitment to something unproven, which means overcoming inertia.	Nothing. You benefit from inertia. Your job is not to give them a reason to overcome it.
Your enemy	**Inertia.** Doing nothing is always the client's safest option.	**Drift.** Small irritations nobody raises, accumulating quietly.
What failure costs	The time you spent. Painful, survivable.	**The entire future revenue stream, permanently** — plus the acquisition cost you already paid.
The hardest moment	The finals pitch, where three firms present and one wins.	The quarterly review after a bad year, where you have nothing good to say and still have to turn up.
How you are measured	Mandates won, assets raised, pipeline.	Retention, net flows, additional mandates.
Horizon	A search cycle: six to eighteen months.	Years, sometimes decades.

THE THING WORTH UNDERSTANDING ABOUT THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THEM

They are not rivals and the firm does not value them equally in the way you might expect.

From doc 42: a client is worth the present value of the *whole* relationship, not this year's fee. So **retention protects more value than acquisition creates, per unit of effort** — but acquisition creates the thing retention protects. Neither works without the other, and a firm that is only good at one of them either shrinks quietly or churns expensively.

3 What each actually does on a Tuesday

SALES · the week	RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT · the week
· **Mapping prospects — who should be a client but isn't**	· **Quarterly and annual reviews with the board**
· Consultant meetings, often with nothing to sell	· Explaining performance — especially bad performance
· Watching for triggers: a CIO leaves, a rival is downgraded	· Answering the question they asked last time
· RFP and DDQ responses — coordinating twenty teams	· Noticing the early signs that a client is unhappy
· Building the pitch, rehearsing the pitch	· Bringing the rest of the firm to them
· Finals presentations to a trustee board	· Additional mandates from a client who already trusts you
· Fee negotiation	· Managing a problem before it becomes an exit
· Deciding which searches NOT to enter	· Reporting, and the unglamorous machinery of being easy to deal with
Most of this produces nothing. Then occasionally it produces a lot.	*Mostly invisible. Visible only when it fails.*

Figure 1 — Practitioner understanding of how these functions run, not a Goldman disclosure.

PART II

What selling actually is here

4 What you are actually selling

Start with the problem, because it is genuinely strange and it shapes everything.

> You are selling **an outcome that does not exist yet, cannot be sampled, and will not be judged for years.** The buyer has to commit before they can possibly know.

Compare that to almost any other sale. Software has a demo. A car has a test drive. A building can be visited. A pension scheme handing over a billion pounds gets *a process, a team and a track record* — none of which guarantees anything about the future, and all three of which every competitor also has.

So what is the client actually buying? Four things, and notice how little of it is performance:

1. **The credibility of the claim.** Not the returns — the believability of the process that is supposed to produce them.
2. **Evidence you will still be there.** That the team will not leave, the firm will not retreat from the strategy, and someone will still be explaining it in year seven.
3. **Defensibility.** Something they can put in front of their own board, now and in five years if it goes wrong.
4. **Ease.** That dealing with you will not be a source of work for them.

5 The reframe: you are not persuading, you are de-risking

This is the single most useful idea in the document, and it falls straight out of the agency point in doc 32.

WHAT THE TRUSTEE IS ACTUALLY ASKING

They are **not** asking "is this the best manager?" They are asking:

"Can I defend having chosen this?"

Because they are an agent, spending money that is not theirs, and they will be asked to justify it — possibly years later, possibly by someone hostile, possibly after it has gone badly.

> So the job is not to make the client *want* to say yes. It is to make it **easy to say yes and easy to justify having said yes.** Selling here is risk removal, not persuasion.

Once you see that, the whole industry becomes legible:

The thing	What it is actually for
The due diligence questionnaire	Not red tape. **It is the defence file.** It is what the trustee puts in the drawer so the decision survives scrutiny in 2032. *You have built one of these.*
Consultant ratings	Third-party validation. A trustee who chose a consultant-rated manager has an answer ready. One who did not, does not.
Brand	Not vanity. "We appointed Goldman" is easier to defend to a board than a name nobody recognises — even if the second firm is better. That is rational risk management on the client's part.
Track record and tenure	Evidence the thing is repeatable rather than lucky, and that the people responsible will still be there.
Being boringly reliable	The reports arrive on time and are right. Unglamorous, and it is a genuine competitive advantage because it reduces the client's workload.

6 The trigger model: you do not win clients, you win searches

This is the thing almost nobody outside the industry understands, and saying it would mark you out immediately.

> Institutional clients almost never switch manager because someone persuaded them to. **They switch because something triggered a search** — and then they choose from whoever is already credible.

The triggers:

- An incumbent underperforms for long enough that the board has to act
- A consultant downgrades the incumbent
- The scheme's CIO or a key person leaves
- A strategy review, a de-risking step, a change in funding level
- A merger, a corporate transaction, a new regulation
- A brand new allocation — a decision to enter private markets for the first time

THE TWO CONSEQUENCES, AND THEY DEFINE THE JOB

1. A sale usually begins with somebody else's loss. Most new mandates are funded by firing an incumbent. Which is sobering, and is also why nobody in this industry is glib about retention.

2. You cannot create the trigger. You can only be the obvious alternative when it comes. Which means the real work is being known, rated and credible *before* there is anything to sell — often for years, producing no revenue at all.

That is the honest answer to "how do you win the client over": **mostly, by having done the work long before the moment arrived.**

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR HOW YOU TALK ABOUT SALES

If you describe sales as persuading people to switch, you will sound like someone who has imagined the job. If you describe it as **being in position when a search happens**, you sound like someone who has seen it.

7 Who is actually in the room

One more thing that distinguishes this from most sales: **there is rarely a single buyer.** A mandate decision typically involves a trustee board of six to twelve people, several of whom are not investment professionals, plus an investment consultant, plus sometimes the sponsoring employer.

Which means:

- **You are presenting to a committee**, where the least technical person in the room may be the one who decides. Explaining clearly is not a soft skill here; it is the skill.
- **Someone in that room is sceptical**, and part of the job is knowing who and why before you walk in.
- **The consultant may matter more than the client.** You often win or lose at the shortlist stage, which happens before you are in the room at all.
- **Decisions are slow because they are collective.** Nobody can say yes alone.

PART III

Against other kinds of sales

8 How this differs from markets sales and from banking

	MARKETS SALES (S&T)	BANKING COVERAGE	ASSET MANAGEMENT SALES
Selling	Immediacy and capacity. The ability to transact size now at a known price.	Judgement on a decision the client makes once.	A multi-year outcome that cannot be tested in advance.
The relationship is	A route to the call. **You then win the order on price today.** Yesterday's service does not buy a worse price.	Maintained for years to win a single transaction. Can earn nothing for a decade.	**The thing being bought.** Not a route to the product — the product.
Feedback	Minutes. Measured constantly, often daily.	Months to close; years to know if the advice was good.	Years. Sometimes never.
Payoff shape	Many small, repeated.	Rare and enormous.	An annuity. Won once, paid for years.
What good looks like	Fast, sharp, competitive, resilient to a constant scoreboard.	Stamina, precision, orchestration under deadline.	Patient, credible, clear, and still there in year seven.

THE ONE-LINE CONTRAST WORTH MEMORISING

In markets sales, the relationship earns you the right to compete on price. In asset management sales, the relationship is what is being bought.

That sentence answers "why asset management sales rather than markets sales" on its own, and it is the kind of thing that makes an interviewer sit up.

PART IV

Attributes and values

9 The nine things they actually look for

Not "communication skills". These are the real ones, and several of them are counterintuitive. My characterisation, based on how the function works.

#	Attribute	Why, and what it looks like
1	**Listening more than talking**	The commonest misconception about sales is that it is talking. **In institutional sales the person who best understands the client's actual constraint wins.** Most pitches lose because the firm answered a question nobody asked.
2	**Credibility over charisma**	You are selling to professionals who have seen hundreds of pitches. **Slickness is a negative signal** — it suggests the polish is doing work the substance cannot.
3	**Translation, both directions**	Taking what a portfolio manager says and making it legible to a trustee who is not a specialist. And taking what a trustee is worried about back to the investment team in a form they will act on.
4	**Patience with long cycles**	Six to eighteen months, and much of the work produces nothing for years. People who need frequent wins do not last.
5	**Organisation and follow-through**	An RFP is a project across many teams. A finals pitch is a production. **Dropping a ball here is not a small error** — it is evidence about how you would handle their money.
6	**Being the least expert person in the room on the investment**	…while being the most expert on the client. Comfortable not being the smartest person present, and knowing exactly when to bring in someone who is.
7	**Resilience to losing**	Three firms pitch; one wins. **You will lose most of what you work on**, often for reasons unrelated to how well you did.
8	**Judgement about when not to pitch**	Underrated. Knowing which searches you cannot win saves enormous resource, and a salesperson who only ever says "let's go for it" is expensive.
9	**Technical fluency without being an investor**	Enough to be credible and to ask the right question. Not enough to pretend you run the portfolio — and claiming you do is a fast way to be found out.

10 The values — and why they are also the commercial strategy

This is the part that will sound like platitudes if you say it badly and like insight if you say it well.

In a business where revenue is an annuity, **short-term extraction destroys more value than it creates.** The ethics and the economics point in the same direction, which is unusual and worth saying.

Value	What it looks like in practice, and why it pays
Honesty about performance	The fastest way to lose an institutional client is to spin a bad quarter. They have the data. **Explaining a bad period honestly is the single highest-trust act available**, and it is the one that gets you the next mandate.
Not overselling	You will still be there in three years when it did not work. Overselling is borrowing from your own future.
Saying "we're not right for this"	Counterintuitive and genuinely powerful. A salesperson who occasionally rules themselves out becomes believable when they do not.
Client's interests first	Goldman's first business principle, and in this business it is also the dominant strategy — because being trusted with the *next* decision is the only durable asset.
Long-term greedy	The old Gus Levy phrase, and the most honest description of self-interest in this industry there is.

11 What "building a relationship" concretely looks like

You asked for this specifically, and it deserves a direct answer because the phrase is usually empty.

> **IT IS NOT LUNCHES**
>
> Entertaining exists, it is a small part of the job, and it is nobody's competitive advantage. Describing relationship-building as hospitality is the fastest way to sound like you have never seen it.

What it actually is — seven concrete things:

1. **Being useful when there is nothing to sell.** Sending the research they would actually find relevant. Making an introduction. Flagging something that affects them. This is most of it, and it happens for years before any revenue.
2. **Knowing their constraints better than they expect.** Their funding level, their governance calendar, their consultant, which board member is sceptical and why, what they got wrong last time and are now cautious about.
3. **Remembering what they said and following up.** Astonishingly rare, and it is the cheapest form of differentiation that exists.
4. **Answering the awkward question fast.** Speed on a difficult question is worth more than polish on an easy one.
5. **Making their job easier.** Giving them something they can take to their board without having to rework it. See the DDQ.
6. **Turning up when it is bad. This is the actual test.** Anyone turns up to pitch. The relationship is made in the meeting after a bad year, where you have nothing good to say and you come anyway, with an honest explanation.
7. **Consistency of person.** Relationships are with people. High turnover in a coverage team is a real commercial problem, which is part of why these firms care so much about retention and tenure.

> **THE SENTENCE THAT TIES SALES AND RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT TOGETHER**
>
> People describe them as opposites — one wins, one keeps. **They are the same activity at different points in the cycle.**
>
> Sales is building credibility with somebody before they need you. Relationship management is maintaining credibility with somebody who already chose you. In both cases the currency is identical: **being the counterparty who makes a difficult decision easier to make and easier to defend.**

PART V

You

12 Your evidence, mapped

What you have	What it maps to
The DDQ portal — 400 questions, 20 teams	**The single best piece of evidence you have for sales.** The DDQ is the defence file — the artefact that makes a client's decision survivable. You built the thing the sale actually runs on, and you coordinated twenty teams you had no authority over to do it.
Fifty segregated market openings	What happens after a win. You know the sale is not finished when the client says yes — which most candidates do not.
Pictet Global Client Group	You sat inside this exact function. Say what you *saw*, honestly — see the caution below.
The clothing shop	Matching stock to the person rather than selling harder, and customers whose value was their return visits. The structure of the incentive is right; keep the scale caveat.
The house hunt	Coordinating people with no authority to a decision by a deadline. That is a finals process in miniature.

THE HONESTY CAUTION, REPEATED BECAUSE IT MATTERS

Saad is right. **Do not say you rotated through sales or relationship management unless you did.** A Superday interviewer may well be from that team, and a mismatch against your CV or a reference costs the offer.

The honest positioning is just as strong: *"I sat alongside the client-facing teams and supported them on [the DDQ work / prospect material / market openings], and that's the part of the business I want to move towards."* Wanting to move toward something is a completely normal and credible thing for a summer analyst to say.

13 The lines

Four you can use. Do not use all four — pick the one that fits the question.

IF ASKED WHY SALES RATHER THAN RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT

"Honestly I'd be happy in either, and I think they're more similar than people assume — both are about being the person who makes a difficult decision easier to make and easier to defend. But what pulls me to the sales side is that it's the harder version of the same problem: with an existing client you've already got the benefit of the doubt, and in a search you have to build that from nothing, usually against two firms who are also credible. And I like that it's a long game — you can't create the moment a client decides to look, you can only have done enough beforehand that you're on the list when they do."

IF ASKED WHAT YOU THINK THE JOB ACTUALLY INVOLVES

"I think the misconception is that it's about persuading people. From what I saw at Pictet it's much more about removing risk from somebody else's decision. A trustee isn't really asking whether you're the best manager, they're asking whether they can defend having picked you — to their board, and possibly in five years if it's gone badly. So most of the work is making it easy to say yes and easy to justify having said yes. Which is why the due diligence questionnaire matters so much, and why it was interesting to work on rather than just administrative."

IF ASKED WHY ASSET MANAGEMENT SALES RATHER THAN MARKETS SALES

"In markets sales the relationship earns you the right to compete on price — you win the order by being competitive today, and yesterday's service doesn't buy you a worse price. In asset management the relationship is the thing being bought. It's a slower game with a much longer feedback loop, and I'd rather build something that still pays in year ten than win the same order again every morning."

IF ASKED WHAT MAKES SOMEONE GOOD AT IT

"I'd say listening rather than talking, which isn't what people expect from a sales role. Most pitches lose because the firm answered a question nobody asked. And being credible rather than slick — you're presenting to people who've seen hundreds of these, so polish past a certain point starts to look like it's doing work the substance can't. Then probably patience, because you lose most of what you work on and often for reasons that have nothing to do with how well you did it."

THE THREE THINGS TO CARRY INTO THE RECORDING

1. Selling here is de-risking someone else's decision, not persuading them.
2. You do not win clients, you win searches — so the work is being credible long before there is anything to sell.
3. In markets sales the relationship gets you the right to compete; here the relationship is the product.

Any one of those, said once, will put you ahead of a field that mostly talks about being a people person.

Sourcing and confidence. Goldman does not publish a CSG organisational chart, and the function names in section 1 come from job postings rather than disclosure — treat the structure as the general industry shape and ask them about theirs. The characterisations of how sales and relationship management differ, the trigger model, the attributes in section 9 and the concrete behaviours in section 11 are standard practitioner understanding of how institutional asset management coverage works, not a published Goldman view: they are directionally reliable and will vary at the edges by firm and by segment. The commercial points about client lifetime value, retention asymmetry and the agency problem are developed in docs 32 and 42 and rest on the reasoning there. Goldman's first business principle and the "long-term greedy" phrase attributed to Gus Levy are well established. Everything about your own experience is yours, and the caution about not overstating your role at Pictet comes from your friend Saad and is worth following.